



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

DATE:
9/10/2024

COMMITTEE:
Elementary and Secondary Education

TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES

WITNESS NAME

INDIVIDUAL:

WITNESS NAME:
JOELLE DIXON

PHONE NUMBER:

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:

TITLE:

ADDRESS:
801 S. BUSINESS 61

CITY:
BOWLING GREEN

STATE:
MO

ZIP:
63334

ATTENDANCE:
Written

SUBMIT DATE:
9/5/2024 10:45 AM

THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.

1. When claiming our business in the beginning, the new system did not attach any information to the account. There was a section where it showed contract application, by accident that was selected. When I called the childcare system to let them know of this error on my behalf and it not connecting our accounts. I was told then it would be fixed, this was in the first few weeks of the launch of the new system. Just last week, the week of August 26th, I called to speak to the childcare system regarding another issue (#6) I made them aware of this again. The application for contract was still showing on our account. I was then informed that it would be 45-60 days to have that application removed. Our contract renewal is due by 9/30/2024. I asked if that would affect our contract renewal process? What does that mean families? I was told that only new families would not be able to add us as a provider until its resolved. I was then told they were going to "expedite".
2. Families who have approval through our facility are still not getting paid for. I cannot submit their attendance through Kinderconnect. They do show on KinderConnect during the entire process, until the last screen. On the last screen that child does not display. This has been an ongoing issue since March 2024. Every time I have called, another issue has arisen either with this child or it effects another child who hasn't had a problem before. Leaving this family without their daycare paid, thankfully we still have grant funds available to cover their portions. (This issue just was resolved in the last few days.)
3. I have one child who has not attended since their parent passed in 2023. They still show up on KinderConnect for attendance. There still is error showing when I don't select them on attendance. PPR's were sent/I have called regarding this issue as well. Nothing was ever resolved. The child finally stopped showing up on our actives when their subsidy ran out. Like all the PPR's I have put in all have been 'assigned' since May 2024.
4. PPR's were put in for the family listed in #2, only November & December 2023 were fixed for the missed payments. That was for both children, when that family renewed their subsidy nothing showed up during the switch over to the new system. No PPR's have been approved for the one sibling with the issue listed above. I have spent one Saturday from 8am til almost noon on the phone with the new childcare system (also with the guardian) trying to get this issue resolved. Just an estimate of 12 hours on the phone including hold times to get the same issue, not resolved with the same response. They are going to 'expedite' the issue, which can take up to 45-60 days.
5. I have informed families 30-60 days before their expirations, to help them get a jump start on the process of renewing their subsidies. The system does not have a renew tab present for most of these families even showing like it's supposed to. Or the system including the staff won't accept the information being sent in.
6. One family has resent their requested information 3 different times now. They have also called

multiple times and left call back numbers and never got a return phone call. This same family, I helped them 30 days if not more before their expiration date. Their subsidy expired in May, and still has not been approved. When asked, they are told the same thing, 'it's been expedited, could take up to 45-60 days.' They have given the same excuse for every call. No family can afford to wait this long for approval, that's far too long.

7. A new family who would like to enroll with our program using a subsidy who was already approved with another provider was told it would be 45-60 days before they could get it moved over to us as a provider. This same family called again to be told, I as a provider could call and expedite the process for them to get the child in here faster. So I called the childcare system, once I spoke to them they denied that they have told families these things. This same family was also told that now their family will have to wait now 90 days for their family to be moved over.

8. There have been multiple times either families or myself have requested call backs to never have them returned. One time I called and the number rang and rang. Called right back for it to be picked up. This was when I was calling almost every other day trying to get issues resolved for a family or at least help.

9. Recently two new families are now showing that their children are authorized for our center. As their provider, they are not showing on our end yet. This is very frustrating for the families and also the provider.



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WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: TERESA L WOODS		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS: 19820 PIKE 136			
CITY: LOUISIANA		STATE: MO	ZIP: 63353
		ATTENDANCE: Written	SUBMIT DATE: 8/29/2024 4:32 PM
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			

I am a grandmother of two boys ages 1 and 4, my grandsons were placed with my by the state of Missouri. I live on a very limited income and am still raising two teenage girls and caring full time for my mother who has Alzheimer's.

I depend on the subsidy to pay for daycare for both boys as I get no money from the state for caring for my grandsons and I just can't afford daycare and I can't have them with me while I care for my mother during the day.

The boys mother is working a full time job as expected, there is no child support as the fathers of the boys are not in their lives, don't work and pretty much are in and out of jail so I need all the help I can get and the daycare subsidy is a huge blessing.

I am in support of the subsidy, I can't attend the hearing.



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WITNESS NAME

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:

WITNESS NAME:
VICTORIA SMITH

PHONE NUMBER:

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:
KIDZ OF JOY DEVELOPMENT CENTER; M.EL.K. ACADEMY

TITLE:
OWNER AND DIRECTOR

ADDRESS:
6100 MADISON AVE

CITY:
SAINT LOUIS

STATE:
MO

ZIP:
63134

ATTENDANCE:
Written

SUBMIT DATE:
9/9/2024 4:51 PM

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Without proper consistent and adequate funding, there are families that are forced to be deprived of quality childcare. We have about 10-15 families that have yet to approved by DESE for funding and about 122 payments, that have not been paid. Children should be able to learn and grow their minds so that they may be equipped with the most knowledge before entering kindergarten. Without anyone actively fostering knowledge and essential developmental skills, these same children will go on to struggle in grade school and those issues could progress and follow them all the way to adulthood. Although, this could be avoided if they are given the chance to attend these various learning centers with the help of governmental funding. This is affecting more than just the children. Not only are they forced to miss out on a safe, loving, and enriching environment, but their parents are also suffering due to the fact that they have to struggle to find a babysitter so that they may attend work. If they can't find anyone to supervise their child(ren), then they would have to miss work which affects their attendance and consequently, their income. This creates a vicious cycle of struggling to be able to provide for their children, as childcare can be a major expense for most families aside from their everyday and monthly expenses. In addition to this, the loyal, dedicated and hardworking staff of these development centers will be affected if not enough parents are able to receive childcare. This matter causes enrollment to be low while the expenses to keep to the business up and running remains steady; thus, putting us in a difficult position. We do not want to continue to decrease the work hours for our staff, but in order to pay them and keep them on our team, this is what we must do unless funding is provided.



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WITNESS NAME

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:

WITNESS NAME:
ALENA MALONE

PHONE NUMBER:

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:
LOVELY CHILD DEVELOPMENT CENTER

TITLE:
OWNER

ADDRESS:
10116 NEW HALLS FERRY ROAD

CITY:
FERGUSON

STATE:
MO

ZIP:
63136

EMAIL:

ATTENDANCE:

SUBMIT DATE:
9/10/2024 12:00 AM

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9/10/2024

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WITNESS NAME

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:

WITNESS NAME:
ALISHA TRAMMELL

PHONE NUMBER:

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:
DEXTER CHAMBER OF COMMERCE

TITLE:
EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR

ADDRESS:
515 W. MARKET

CITY:
DEXTER

STATE:
MO

ZIP:
63841

ATTENDANCE:
Written

SUBMIT DATE:
9/8/2024 8:29 PM

THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.

Dear Members of the House,

I am writing to bring to your attention the urgent crisis facing our local childcare centers due to significant delays in the processing and payment of childcare subsidies. As the Economic Developer for the City of Dexter and Executive Director of the Dexter Chamber of Commerce, I have seen firsthand how this crisis is devastating our community.

In Dexter, our childcare centers have been severely impacted by months-long backlogs in subsidy payments. Providers have struggled to keep their doors open while waiting for funds that are essential to their operations. The situation has reached a breaking point, with one local daycare center forced to make the heart-wrenching decision to close its doors on September 30. This center serves 45 children, but only 13 families pay privately. Without the timely receipt of subsidy payments, the center can no longer afford to pay its employees, leaving parents scrambling to find alternative care. With fewer childcare options available, many parents may be forced to make the difficult decision to leave the workforce entirely to stay home with their children, further exacerbating our community's economic challenges.

The delays in subsidy payments not only strain the financial viability of childcare providers but also place an additional burden on their daily operations. Providers often spend hours on hold with the Office of Childhood, attempting to resolve payment issues, which detracts from the time they need to dedicate to the children in their care.

The repercussions of this crisis extend beyond daycare centers and into the realm of foster care. Foster parents, who already go above and beyond for the children they welcome into their homes, are also experiencing subsidy payment delays. One couple in Dexter shared with me their struggle: despite their deep commitment to fostering, the lack of payments has made it financially unsustainable to continue. These are the families we need in our community—those who foster out of love, not for financial gain—but without the necessary support, they are being forced to reconsider their ability to foster.

I urge you to take immediate action to address the childcare subsidy crisis that is causing irreparable harm to our childcare providers, foster families, and, most importantly, our children. We need streamlined processes, timely payments, and adequate support for those who care for our most vulnerable. Our local providers and foster parents should not be burdened by administrative failures that hinder their ability to do the vital work our communities depend on.

Thank you for your attention to this critical issue. I look forward to working together to find solutions that will stabilize and support our childcare and foster care systems.

**Sincerely,
Alisha Trammell
Executive Director
Dexter Chamber of Commerce**



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WITNESS NAME		
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:		
WITNESS NAME: ALISON MAY		PHONE NUMBER:
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: KINDERCARE LEARNING COMPANIES; KINDERCARE EDUCATION LLC; KINDERCARE LEARNING CENTERS LLC		TITLE:
ADDRESS:		
CITY: HAZELWOOD	STATE: MO	ZIP: 63042
ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 9/9/2024 3:40 PM
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.		

Dear Chairman Pollitt and Members of the Elementary and Secondary Education Committee:

On behalf of KinderCare Learning Companies (KinderCare), thank you for convening an informational hearing of the House Committee on Elementary and Secondary Education to discuss the Missouri Child Care Subsidy Program. KinderCare respectfully submits the following testimony highlighting ongoing challenges within the child care subsidy program. As you know, the Missouri State Subsidy Program is an essential early learning and workforce program. It allows low-income parents to work while their children are cared for in safe, stable, and nurturing environments—in short, it's a critical program for families, employers, and the state economy.

In Missouri, KinderCare proudly operates 23 early learning centers, serving just over 2,000 children. KinderCare is committed to providing all children with high-quality care, regardless of family income. Moreover, 36% of the children enrolled in our centers participate in the Missouri Child Care Subsidy Program.

The following testimony will help draw attention to the barriers children, families, and providers face in Missouri. Current subsidy challenges fall into three primary categories, including: technology, delays in family approval, and inaccurate payments. Each has negatively impacted the child care industry in some cases since the end of 2023. KinderCare continues to partner with the Office of Childhood (OOC) within in the Department of Elementary and Secondary Education (DESE) and appreciates the work they have done to identify lasting solutions.

1) Technology related challenges

Families that participate in the child care subsidy program are required to check their children both in and out of care via an online portal twice daily. This process, of punching attendance at a point of service device, can result in inaccuracies in tracking attendance and billing. Devices do not work, parents are rushed to get to their job, and corrections are cumbersome. This frequently results in child care providers not receiving payment for care provided. Since the start of Aug. 2024, the online portal to punch children in and out has been accessible via Android operating system only, whereas previously parents could access the portal through either an iOS or Android operating system device. Many of our parents successfully logged child attendance through their Apple (iOS) phone but are now unable.

Furthermore, the state provides Android tablets to child care centers that allow parents to punch their children in and out of care. For every 30 children receiving subsidy, one (1) Android tablet is provided to the center. While the majority of our Missouri child care centers serve more than 30 subsidy children none of our centers has more than one tablet, and in one case the tablet at the center is inoperable. These tablets are old and crash frequently. Technology challenges such as these have created over 4,500 missed punches during the month of August alone resulting in losses totaling more than \$200,000. These payments are essential to the operation of our business. And, missed punches become the responsibility of the parent who we know are unable to pay.

- **Recommendations:** (1) Allow child care providers to manually adjust attendance each month to ensure that full and accurate payment for care provided is received; (2) Ensure both Android and iOS operating systems support required attendance activities via the portal; and (3) Upgrade state issued tablets and ensure one working tablet is available for every 30 children per center.

2) Backlog of subsidy applications leading to significant delays in initial authorization and reauthorization

We appreciate the work DESE continues to do to address the backlog of applications; however, this challenge persists. Delays in authorizations are impacting children, families, and providers in catastrophic ways. When a family is unable to receive authorization for the first time or reauthorization, they are faced with the difficult decision of either leaving the workforce or placing their child in potentially unsafe care arrangements. This is unacceptable and we plead with the state to remedy the backlog and ensure families receive authorization within 30-days, allowing them to continue accessing the child care they so desperately need.

Over the last few months, KinderCare has had at least 60 families forced to disenroll from our programs due to the lengthy delay in receiving their reauthorization. We have an additional 30 or more new families who are ready to enroll, but then due to delays in their initial authorization were unable to secure the child care they require. Whether initial authorization or reauthorization, these families must receive approval in a timely fashion and providers must not be penalized for working with families to provide them with continuity of care.

- **Recommendations:** (1) Swiftly work to eliminate the backlog of subsidy applications—prioritizing renewals followed by new authorizations—to ensure families are authorized within 30-days; and (2) Support child care providers with continued payment during the redetermination period so families are not forced to disenroll.

3) Inaccurate subsidy reimbursements

Payment inaccuracies including over and under payments and missing payments significantly impact day to day operations of child care centers. Timely and accurate payments promote financial stability for providers and families alike. When a business is unable to depend on the accuracy of reimbursements operations are jeopardized. Further, without tackling this challenge current providers may decide to forgo working with the state and no longer offer subsidized child care. The ripple effect of such a scenario would be devastating to communities across Missouri. Should fewer providers participate in the child care subsidy program a smaller number of Missouri parents will be able to consistently attend work.

- **Recommendation:** Reduce and promptly rectify payment inaccuracies and ensure moving forward all providers receive subsidy reimbursements in a timely fashion with a significant reduction in payment errors.

Thank you for the opportunity to submit written testimony on the challenges surrounding the administration of the child care subsidy program in Missouri. We appreciate the committee exploring the ongoing challenges and thank DESE for finding lasting solutions. Please view KinderCare as a partner, committed to providing high-quality child care and early learning programs and supporting working families throughout Missouri. Should you have any questions, please do not hesitate to contact me at:



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WITNESS NAME

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:

WITNESS NAME:
AMANDA G TILFORD

PHONE NUMBER:

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:
DESTINY LEARNING CENTER

TITLE:
DIRECTOR

ADDRESS:
4914 PRAIRIE RIDGE ST

CITY:
COLUMBIA

STATE:
MO

ZIP:
65202

ATTENDANCE:
Written

SUBMIT DATE:
9/9/2024 1:33 PM

THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.

As a childcare center director, the State of Missouri Office of Childhood and all it's subsidiary offices have put many centers out of business and created dire situations for countless others. Our center alone has not been paid for some students since December of 2023. Each month the number of students we are missing payment for continues to increase: January (2). February (2), March (3), April (3), May (4), June (6), July (9), August (11). Multiple families have been waiting 2+ months for their subsidy to be approved or renewed, or even to simply move from one center to another due to their previous center closing because of lack of payment from the State of Missouri. These offices have completed multiple changes over the last 18 months, none of which are functioning properly yet and are causing centers countless extra hours of paperwork and follow up. We have experienced issues with the MOPD system, CPR submissions, Annual Contract Renewals, New Approvals and Renewals of Families, Grant non-payment or EXTREME late payment with late communication, and so much more. In addition to all of this, wait times on the phone are 2-3 hours or longer. Our number one priority as a childcare center is the children we care for and their families. We have not received any corrections of any of the issues we have submitted since January regarding Subsidy and since September regarding Grants. Between unpaid grants that were awarded, and unpaid subsidies for children in our care, we are owed over \$100,000 from the State of Missouri and Office of Childhood.



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WITNESS NAME

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:

WITNESS NAME:
ANITA JEWELL COCKRUM

PHONE NUMBER:

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:
ABILITY KC MARY SHAW BRANTON THERAPEUTIC PRESCHOOL
AND OUTPATIENT SERVICES

TITLE:
PROGRAM DIRECTOR FOR
EARLY EDUCATION AND
DEVELOPM

ADDRESS:
3101 N MAIN

CITY:
KANSAS CITY

STATE:
MO

ZIP:
64111

ATTENDANCE:
In-Person

SUBMIT DATE:
9/6/2024 4:21 PM

THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.

Nationally accredited by NAEYC, and state licensed, our early education therapeutic preschool classrooms offer a caring, inclusive environment that provide children ages 1 to 5 years old with a wide range of medical, therapeutic, and educational services. By delivering therapeutic services within a developmentally appropriate and natural environment, our highly experienced team can help young children of all abilities maximize their potential. Ability KC's inclusive classrooms bring together children with disabilities and their typically developing peers, fostering an environment of mutual growth and understanding. Due to the needs of our children's, our program maintains a lower staff-to-child ratio than is required by childcare licensing to ensures exceptional, individualized care and support for each child and their families. Additionally, we employ a team of therapists, intervention specialists, social workers, and other support staff who collaborate with classroom staff to deliver a holistic experience, tailored to the unique goals of every child.

Operating through this model, we are able to remove some of the stress that families with children who have disability face when trying to balance work, childcare, home life and intensive therapy visits, by providing this care in one location. As a result, our operating budget margins are limited and every dollar received is vital to the sustainability of our program.

The national crisis in early education is never more evident than when viewing it through the lens of the marginalized communities we seek to serve. Located in the heart of Kansas City, we are uniquely positioned to meet the needs of the most and diverse area of our community. As such, we believe barriers that we face due to the current subsidy crisis is representative of the most significant impact that can be seen across our state. We would like to present the following details to the impact on our program for consideration:

Financial Strain: Due to limited or delayed responsiveness, delayed state reimbursements and significant discrepancies/errors, our program is facing severe financial challenges. The following program specific challenges have made it difficult to cover operational costs, pay staff, and maintain quality programming and enrollment.

* More than \$10,000 in unreimbursed dollars (January 1 through June 30)

* Discrepancy in children listed as authorized/reimbursed (January 1 through July 31) resulting in additional

staff hours to provide oversight.

* Reimbursement less than 10% of expected pay for month of July.

*Expired contract as of April 1, 2024

*Extensive staff hours devoted to following up

*Lack of access to live contact to resolve concerns

*Inability to obtain appropriate reimbursement

*Inability to track active enrollment

*Providing care for 15 children that are interested subsidy clients that cannot currently confirm eligibility, resulting in potential lost revenue to our program.

Program Reductions:

*Reduced from 7-6 classrooms

*Restructured care to reduce infant and toddler programming from 3 to 1 classroom to reduce overhead

*Reducing classroom space

Staffing Issues:

*Difficulty hiring and maintaining high quality staff due to restricted resources

*Difficulty providing appropriate training and support due to restricted resources.

*Increased staff absences due to burnout

*Increasing mixed age classroom to reduce staffing overhead

*Moving from 16 children with 6 staff to 24 children with 6 staff

Parent Concerns:

*6 current families dependent on subsidy have uncertainty of their status

*The delays have caused stress and uncertainty for families

*As other funding opportunities have faded, increased stress exists for families because subsidy enrollment is backlogged

*Families who already face additional stressors due to having children with disabilities are now facing difficult choices between paying for their care, withdrawing and/or participating in therapy.

*Some parents are having to choose between their jobs and care for their children, often falling further into poverty

*Potential loss of childcare due to eventual need for program to reduce funding loss.

Community Impact:

*The crisis has broader implications for the community. With fewer child care options available, parents are

struggling to find alternative arrangements, which can affect local businesses and the economy as a whole.

We are actively seeking solutions and advocating for timely resolution of these subsidy issues to ensure we can continue to provide high-quality early childhood education to our community.



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TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: BRINDA A WILLIAMS		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS: 1130 LAIRE DRIVE			
CITY: ST. LOUIS		STATE: MO	ZIP: 63137
ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 9/9/2024 1:52 PM	
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Issues since the Office of Childhood, under DESE took over childcare

October 2021 - Office of Childhood from the results of the Market Rate Survey (MRS) took 24-28% (depending on the area in MO) away from the childcare subsidy rate in the City & Counties of St. Louis. The decrease due to the MRS was devastating to providers, the OCC took 3 months to reverse the rate back to the original subsidy rate, leaving the city and counties of St. Louis did not get an increase after 3 years, but all rural areas of Missouri were given a rate increase of 24-28%. Let me repeat that so that it is clear, Rural areas of Missouri were given an increase while the city and counties of St. Louis were initially given a decrease and then put back at the base rate, therefore not receiving an increase yet again! The Office of Childhood sent out notification that providers would receive a change in their subsidy base rate, making sure to not say an increase or decrease, just saying there would be a rate change. In 2021, providers filled out a Market Rate Survey, the city and counties of St. Louis filled this survey out in error, due to the wording of the survey. The results of the survey caused St. Louis City and County providers to receive this decrease in their subsidy. Providers wrote to the Office of Childhood's Pamela Thomas, and the decrease was overturned due to this decrease being unlawful! The OCC promised to backdate the missing amounts, but many have not seen this refund as of today's date. The current MRS has not been implemented as of this date, what are the concerns? According to numerous sources the current MRS rates are high and being questioned, but when the rates were low (due to providers filling out the MRS incorrectly) and we were given a decrease no one questioned those results? To be clear, the current MRS was completed in April (2024) and we still don't have the results and it is still not being implemented because the provides rates are being questioned? So, when it is in their favor (OCC), not ours (providers) it is questioned, got it!

Pandemic funding - When looking at the OCC spend plan for ARPA funding, repeatedly priority was given to Rural areas, and the city & counties of St. Louis was excluded. Once again, disproportionately rural areas were given priority over the city & counties of St. Louis. There are owners in rural Missouri who started the pandemic with one childcare center and ended the pandemic with FOUR childcare centers...thanks to the disproportionate priority of grant funding given to rural areas...again, ONE owner now has FOUR childcares because of the priority given to rural areas!

June 2023 - MOPD new system - The OCC changed the previous Missouri Professional system for child care providers, and it was so poorly implemented that as of December 2023 providers still were not able to set up their accounts! There was little to no help, long wait times on the phone to get help, and the system still does not work correctly. And now that it has been a year, childcare educators now must

go into the system and renew it, while the system is difficult to navigate and still so many are struggling, an ENTIRE year later. It is taking months “renew your membership”. The system doesn’t transfer all the Professional Development, and when you try to upload a certificate, it will not save the certificate. What is the point of the system if it is not tracking your PD?

September 2023 -

Internal, integrity audit - On September 6, 2023, MO accredited providers received a letter from the Office of Childhood (OOC) stating that “records” show that MO Accredited Child Care Providers’ accounts were incorrectly receiving payments for both Accreditation and Accreditation Disproportionate share rate enhancement. Unfortunately, the letter also stated that 20% of their funding would be cut in less than a month, beginning October 1, 2023.

MO Accredited Providers requested to know what specific records The OOC was referring to that state that receiving both enhancements payments was in error, and why they were given only three weeks to economically prepare for this massive budget cut?

As you are very aware MO subsidy payment stays federally ranked the lowest in the county and that such a major budget cut of 20% (in less than three weeks) resulted in devastating budget cuts, such as:

- Laying off experienced and/or degreed teachers,
- Teachers (currently in school) dropping out,
- Loss of extended childcare hours in the evening and/or weekends,
- MO accredited childcare centers closing,
- Young children being left at home under supervised or worse alone,
- Increased cases of child abuse and/or neglect,
- Increased weekly tuition rates for our already financially strapped MO families.
- Children not prepared for to enter kindergarten,
- Ultimately the loss of high-quality childcare for all Missouri families.

Therefore, cutting our already mediocre budget by 20% was beyond survival for many MO. Accredited childcare centers. The direct work of MO accredited centers in low-income areas of the State that ensures highly effective childcare is a win for all Missourians, and when it was taken away, it was and remains devastating to children.

The state plan states you can receive both the 20% and/or the 30% enhancements if you qualify for one or both enhancements, yet the OOC stated, “why should some get these enhancements and not everyone” (Pam Thomas). The enhancements were set up so more providers would accept child care subsidy (30% disproportionate share, providers care for 50% or more subsidized children), Accreditation enhancement was to help bring quality to Missouri since we don’t have a quality rating system (20% accreditation share, providers are accredited programs). It is worth noting that there are other enhancements as well, but the OCC decided that these two could not be “stacked”.

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December 2023 - New Child Care Subsidy System

Parent issues -

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In order to apply for child care subsidy, you would need the internet, a computer or a smartphone, therefore there was not equitable access to the new system, to apply for child care subsidy.

Parents are currently waiting months (60-90 days) for their childcare to be approved and then months for them to be authorized to their childcare provider. How are parents expected to wait for months?

They are losing their jobs, their children are going without, this has been such a hardship for the entire

family. And most importantly, CHILDREN ARE BEING LEFT IN UNSAFE SPACES!!!! Since we already have spaces for the families to go to apply for child care subsidies and other services, why can't we set these up as satellite offices to assist families that do not have access to the internet, computers and smartphones? Why was this not an option?

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Solutions:

The Office of Childhood needs to automatically renew child care subsidy applications until their new CCDS is fixed.

The Office of Childhood needs to automatically renew providers subsidy contracts until the new CCDS is fixed.

The Office of Childhood needs to pay child care providers on authorization/enrollment versus attendance until their CCDS system is fixed and they can pay providers on time, and the correct rates, instead of the burden of providers to do additional work to submit PPR's and wait months and months for payment.

For all the harm done to childcare providers there needs to be a stipend for the long hours, the stress on their bodies & minds, for the loans, the late fees, for all the debt and negative impact to their businesses. In all the years I have worked in childcare this has been the most horrible experience.



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

DATE:
9/10/2024

COMMITTEE:
Elementary and Secondary Education

TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES

WITNESS NAME

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:

WITNESS NAME:
CARLY S WALTON

PHONE NUMBER:

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:
PEAPOD LEARNING CENTER LLC

TITLE:
OWNER, DIRECTOR

ADDRESS:
1

CITY:
SPRINGFIELD

STATE:
MO

ZIP:
65082

ATTENDANCE:
Written

SUBMIT DATE:
8/29/2024 10:26 PM

THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.

Hello,

I am a small, licensed nature preschool owner in Springfield, Missouri. I have been in business for 16 years, and prior to that was a kindergarten teacher for five years. I have been in early childhood my entire life, it is my passion and my livelihood.

I have an excellent program, I have a commitment to quality, and our programs were chosen by DESE as part of the showcase in 2020 for Conference on the Young Years. I have written many grants, we have had several locations and grown over the years into a very well established and cherished part of the community. We were the first to bring Nature Preschool to Southwest Missouri in 2008. Since then, we have collaborated with many others- even parents who have had children graduate from our programs, to encourage nature learning and exploration in the early childhood and elementary community here. We have many community partners and engage with organizations regularly to promote outdoor education. We want to see this grow, thrive, and to help kids and families access high quality, nature/outdoor focused education. We achieved Missouri Accreditation previously and are pursuing NAEYC accreditation, we sponsor the TEACH scholarship to help our teachers pursue their degrees in ECE, and we are also in the QAR. I also just completed the MOSECA program, I am in the ECE Leadership Fellowship program through Kids Win, and I am on many committees in Springfield to try and promote high quality ECE.

Nature education, high quality early childhood education, and supporting families and teachers are at the forefront of my focus. I accept state subsidy to increase the access to my program for the families that cannot afford it. I have to pay a higher wage to recruit and retain my teachers thus our tuition is higher. We operate on parent tuition and get child care food \$, subsidy from the state, and I do write grants. The ONLY reason I am still operating is because of the grants I have written. I am lucky, I have been writing grants for 20 years. My colleagues are not necessarily able to navigate that system. Most providers do not have the time, staff, or experience to access those means of assistance. Sole proprietors and operators work tirelessly- we are never off work. We are the cook, the janitor, the secretary, the substitute, accountant, and we still have to manage the teachers and help coach and guide our programs. It is five to six full time jobs wrapped into one. Add the child care food paperwork, subsidy paperwork, and grant paperwork and we are talking about needing another two full time people to really do that correctly but we don't have the money to do that.

My center operates at a capacity for 36 kids, in three classrooms. We had more locations and capacity prior to COVID, but were forced to reduce our load and close our award winning farm preschool during that time. Since then, the inflation has gone through the roof, the insurance, staff wages, and other operating costs are up exponentially.

Add to this: We have half our center enrolled in the subsidy program. State subsidy- is supposed to

support the families and centers to make quality care more affordable. We want those kids to have the ability to come to our school.

For me as an administrator: I do not get any benefit from accepting state pay/subsidy, it just creates more work for me . I do it for the kids.

I have not been paid since 2023. My Procure system is still not communicating with kinder connect. So this problem is not fixed. I am so far behind, I am losing money like crazy - paying teachers and staff to be here, providing a really great program, and not getting the tuition the state has promised. I thought it was a temporary situation. We are using savings and grant funds. Like everything, that is just a temporary solution. It's just a matter of time until my savings gets to a point where I have no choice but to shut down or sell. I need to be able to have enough left in my savings that I can still pay my house payment and bills for a year or so while I look for another way to make a living. I do not want to start over at 46. I am a widowed parent with two teenage daughters and a hobby farm, where we used to have a thriving farm preschool program.

I am just one, one of I don't know how many people who have dedicated our lives to education, families, and kids. We are DYING HERE. This is way out of our wheelhouse, and we don't know how to fix it- we spend hours on hold, we don't have time, we are already stressed and overstretched. Small businesses, sweet little daycares that have been so instrumental in the early experiences for children and families in our communities- they are disappearing.

How does a state require so much of their providers and not budget appropriately so that they can be paid? We are literally taking care of the MOST VULNERABLE population, the high-risk, low-income families in crisis. We are as providers not being taken care of yet being asked to take care of these kids for basically free. This is insanity. I want to see what business can afford to operate without income for 3/4 of a year and how many are still open? This is just tragic. It's insanity. It is probably criminal. If I am behind on paying the state, I have huge penalties and interest.

Someone needs to step up and HELP US. We cannot afford to hire attorneys; we are just going to have to quietly close our doors and send our kids elsewhere. I know lots of people are no longer accepting subsidy paid kids or foster pay. They can't afford to.

Please, I implore you, some state representatives, this is a bloodbath. We need action immediately. The problem cannot be just a temporary fix, something is really wrong that this is still going on. No resolutions for the majority of us. How does a budget get this far out of whack? What is going on here?

Besides our daycares/preschools, who else is suffering? Your highest risk population. Your high-risk kids.

Please do what is right for the kids, we are all in this for them.

Sincerely,

Carly S Walton, MSED

Owner, Director

Peapod Learning Center LLC

cell

DVN 002711079



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

DATE:
9/10/2024

COMMITTEE:
Elementary and Secondary Education

TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES

WITNESS NAME

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:

WITNESS NAME:
CAROLINE S THOMAS

PHONE NUMBER:

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:
OUR LITTLE VILLAGE LLC

TITLE:
OWNER

ADDRESS:
203 N PINE ST

CITY:
LA PLATA

STATE:
MO

ZIP:
63549

ATTENDANCE:
Written

SUBMIT DATE:
9/9/2024 9:44 PM

THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.

I wanted to take a moment to reach out as a small business owner. I've jumped through every single hoop that to be able to provide licensed, regulated and quality child care to my communities families. We have passed with flying colors. We are a licensed 28 capacity daycare in Macon county, just south of Adair county. We have eight infant spots and 20 2 year-old spots. It is absolutely vital that the paycheck related to subsidy comes timely and appropriately and without error every single month. The reason for this is staffing is hard, children in this day and age have a great deal of emotional need and balance that our daycare centers provide. The staff that I have are incredible and I would pay them four times my salary if I could. However, that is impossible without consistent funding as promised and contacted by the state! I want to stress the importance of what I said regarding the paycheck that comes from subsidy. It is essentially an input and output system. We input our information just the same as my staff and put their hours. I approve my payroll for my staff and the information should be just as easily approved by DESE. For the hours contracted children in our care have been with us. One of the biggest struggles is the amount of administrative hours that I have to go back and look and see how many mistakes are made on these payouts or if we didn't get paid at all for months and months. We will fight back and forth via email with very polite staff, but why are we spending our time doing this? Why is this data feed so difficult! The coding and the API calls the back end of the day should be built so that it is an automated process with a manual approval at the very end, working smarter and not harder with your data is vitally important to getting these checks cut to our providers so that we can pay our staff and provide for these children so that families can continue to work everyday to support our economic growth. Grant funding for staff retention is also vital at the very heartbeat of keeping good staff. This should be a continuation from year to year for every licensed and subsidy center across the state. It keeps staffing in place to ensure our doors stay open and can support the families needs across the state. We as providers have had to stretch every corner that we can imagine to meet payroll during this lack of payment , as the upcoming stipend is greatly appreciated we are still digging out of holes that have been created by this withholding and non payment disaster.



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DATE:
9/10/2024

COMMITTEE:
Elementary and Secondary Education

TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES

WITNESS NAME

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:

WITNESS NAME:
CHERYL HOWARD

PHONE NUMBER:

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:
NORA STEWART EARLY LEARNING CENTER

TITLE:
DIRECTOR

ADDRESS:
505 EAST ASH STREET

CITY:
COLUMBIA

STATE:
MO

ZIP:
65201

EMAIL:

ATTENDANCE:

SUBMIT DATE:
9/10/2024 12:00 AM

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MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

COMMITTEE: Elementary and Secondary Education			DATE: 9/10/2024	
TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES				
WITNESS NAME				
INDIVIDUAL:				
WITNESS NAME: CHERYL WASHINGTON-HOWARD			PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:			TITLE:	
ADDRESS: 505 E. ASH				
CITY: COLUMBIA,MO			STATE: MO	ZIP: 65201
		ATTENDANCE: In-Person	SUBMIT DATE: 9/10/2024 11:29 AM	
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.				
Why is funding so far behind for our childcare centers				



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DATE:
9/10/2024

COMMITTEE:
Elementary and Secondary Education

TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES

WITNESS NAME

INDIVIDUAL:

WITNESS NAME:
CHRISTINA STOKES

PHONE NUMBER:

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:

TITLE:

ADDRESS:
5450 SHREVE AVE

CITY:
ST. LOUIS

STATE:
MO

ZIP:
63115

ATTENDANCE:
Written

SUBMIT DATE:
9/9/2024 1:57 PM

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Pandemic funding - When looking at the OCC spend plan for ARPA funding, repeatedly priority was given to Rural areas, and the city & counties of St. Louis was excluded. Once again, disproportionately rural areas were given priority over the city & counties of St. Louis. There are owners in rural Missouri who started the pandemic with one childcare center and ended the pandemic with FOUR childcare centers...thanks to the disproportionate priority of grant funding given to rural areas...again, ONE owner now has FOUR childcares because of the priority given to rural areas!

June 2023 - MOPD new system - The OCC changed the previous Missouri Professional system for child care providers, and it was so poorly implemented that as of December 2023 providers still were not able to set up their accounts! There was little to no help, long wait times on the phone to get help, and the system still does not work correctly. And now that it has been a year, childcare educators now must

go into the system and renew it, while the system is difficult to navigate and still so many are struggling, an ENTIRE year later. It is taking months “renew your membership”. The system doesn’t transfer all the Professional Development, and when you try to upload a certificate, it will not save the certificate. What is the point of the system if it is not tracking your PD?

September 2023 -

Internal, integrity audit - On September 6, 2023, MO accredited providers received a letter from the Office of Childhood (OOC) stating that “records” show that MO Accredited Child Care Providers’ accounts were incorrectly receiving payments for both Accreditation and Accreditation Disproportionate share rate enhancement. Unfortunately, the letter also stated that 20% of their funding would be cut in less than a month, beginning October 1, 2023.

MO Accredited Providers requested to know what specific records The OOC was referring to that state that receiving both enhancements payments was in error, and why they were given only three weeks to economically prepare for this massive budget cut?

As you are very aware MO subsidy payment stays federally ranked the lowest in the county and that such a major budget cut of 20% (in less than three weeks) resulted in devastating budget cuts, such as:

- Laying off experienced and/or degreed teachers,
- Teachers (currently in school) dropping out,
- Loss of extended childcare hours in the evening and/or weekends,
- MO accredited childcare centers closing,
- Young children being left at home under supervised or worse alone,
- Increased cases of child abuse and/or neglect,
- Increased weekly tuition rates for our already financially strapped MO families.
- Children not prepared for to enter kindergarten,
- Ultimately the loss of high-quality childcare for all Missouri families.

Therefore, cutting our already mediocre budget by 20% was beyond survival for many MO. Accredited childcare centers. The direct work of MO accredited centers in low-income areas of the State that ensures highly effective childcare is a win for all Missourians, and when it was taken away, it was and remains devastating to children.

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WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

		DATE: 9/10/2024	
COMMITTEE: Elementary and Secondary Education			
TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:			
WITNESS NAME: CHRISTY WILLS ED.D		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: KINDERCARE LEARNING COMPANIES		TITLE: DISTRICT LEADER	
ADDRESS: 2500 HAMPTON AVE			
CITY: ST. LOUIS		STATE: MO	ZIP: 63139
		ATTENDANCE: In-Person	SUBMIT DATE: 9/8/2024 3:37 PM
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			

- 1) Technology related challenges
- 2) Backlog of subsidy applications causing significant initial authorization and reauthorization delays
- 3) Inaccurate subsidy reimbursements



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		DATE: 9/10/2024	
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TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:			
WITNESS NAME: CHRISTY WILLS ED.D		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: KINDERCARE LEARNING CENTER		TITLE: DISTRICT LEADER	
ADDRESS: 2500 HAMPTON AVE			
CITY: ST. LOUIS		STATE: MO	ZIP: 63139
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COMMITTEE: Elementary and Secondary Education		DATE: 9/10/2024	
TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: DANYEL		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS: 208 GRAMPAN ROAD			
CITY: ST. LOUIS		STATE: MO	ZIP: 63137
		ATTENDANCE: Written	SUBMIT DATE: 9/9/2024 1:50 PM
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			

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go into the system and renew it, while the system is difficult to navigate and still so many are struggling, an ENTIRE year later. It is taking months “renew your membership”. The system doesn’t transfer all the Professional Development, and when you try to upload a certificate, it will not save the certificate. What is the point of the system if it is not tracking your PD?

September 2023 -

Internal, integrity audit - On September 6, 2023, MO accredited providers received a letter from the Office of Childhood (OOC) stating that “records” show that MO Accredited Child Care Providers’ accounts were incorrectly receiving payments for both Accreditation and Accreditation Disproportionate share rate enhancement. Unfortunately, the letter also stated that 20% of their funding would be cut in less than a month, beginning October 1, 2023.

MO Accredited Providers requested to know what specific records The OOC was referring to that state that receiving both enhancements payments was in error, and why they were given only three weeks to economically prepare for this massive budget cut?

As you are very aware MO subsidy payment stays federally ranked the lowest in the county and that such a major budget cut of 20% (in less than three weeks) resulted in devastating budget cuts, such as:

- Laying off experienced and/or degreed teachers,
- Teachers (currently in school) dropping out,
- Loss of extended childcare hours in the evening and/or weekends,
- MO accredited childcare centers closing,
- Young children being left at home under supervised or worse alone,
- Increased cases of child abuse and/or neglect,
- Increased weekly tuition rates for our already financially strapped MO families.
- Children not prepared for to enter kindergarten,
- Ultimately the loss of high-quality childcare for all Missouri families.

Therefore, cutting our already mediocre budget by 20% was beyond survival for many MO. Accredited childcare centers. The direct work of MO accredited centers in low-income areas of the State that ensures highly effective childcare is a win for all Missourians, and when it was taken away, it was and remains devastating to children.

The state plan states you can receive both the 20% and/or the 30% enhancements if you qualify for one or both enhancements, yet the OOC stated, “why should some get these enhancements and not everyone” (Pam Thomas). The enhancements were set up so more providers would accept child care subsidy (30% disproportionate share, providers care for 50% or more subsidized children), Accreditation enhancement was to help bring quality to Missouri since we don’t have a quality rating system (20% accreditation share, providers are accredited programs). It is worth noting that there are other enhancements as well, but the OCC decided that these two could not be “stacked”.

October 2023 - OCC took 20% away from childcare providers that were both accredited and receiving the disproportionate share, the disproportionate share is an enhancement given to providers that provide care to at least 50% of their licensed capacity subsidized care. These providers provide care in the most underserved areas, these are the families that live below the poverty line and are receiving subsidy services. The providers are also the largest number of accredited centers in the state...to make this clearer, the providers that are serving the most underserved population are also the childcare centers that are offering the highest quality of care (accredited centers) were the centers that the Office of Childhood under the direction of Pamela Thomas were given a reduction 20% in their funding! This is once again, disproportionately in the Cities and Counties of St. Louis.

December 2023 - New Child Care Subsidy System

Parent issues -

No training was given to parents prior to a brand-new system being implemented for them to apply for child care subsidies.

In order to apply for child care subsidy, you would need the internet, a computer or a smartphone, therefore there was not equitable access to the new system, to apply for child care subsidy.

Parents are currently waiting months (60-90 days) for their childcare to be approved and then months for them to be authorized to their childcare provider. How are parents expected to wait for months?

They are losing their jobs, their children are going without, this has been such a hardship for the entire

family. And most importantly, CHILDREN ARE BEING LEFT IN UNSAFE SPACES!!!! Since we already have spaces for the families to go to apply for child care subsidies and other services, why can't we set these up as satellite offices to assist families that do not have access to the internet, computers and smartphones? Why was this not an option?

Provider issues - Providers continue to lose money due to not being paid on time, the correct amount, and must do the extra work such as Provider Payment Resolution forms. And because they are so backlogged it takes months. Providers do not receive emails once something is received, that something is needed in the new child care data system, or when something is submitted in ProMo, why do providers have to go into each system several times a day to see if there are notifications when an email would alert us to this. Providers have extremely long hold times on the phones....

January 2024 -New Child Care Data System issues - the new childcare data system has not worked for the past 9+ months, the staff in the office of childcare are not able to properly implement this system, they literally did not test the system to make sure it paid providers correctly. The OCC does not have any answers, they just ask for patience, after 9 months of being patient...childcares are closing due to not being paid on time or the correct amount for 9 months! Many providers are taking out loans, they are working long hours without pay so they can pay staff, they are cutting quality programming and staff. This system has been a nightmare, with many, many issues. Providers must upload renewal paperwork into the system and the renewals are not coming through, their words, "there is a glitch" and so many contracts are not being renewed, if you cannot renew your contract, you cannot accept subsidy children. It's the same for anything you must upload, there are "glitches" and so nothing is working properly. As of today, August 30th this system still is not operating correctly, and providers cannot get their child care subsidy contract renewed! Providers are on hold for hours, trying to speak with someone. The ticketing system does not work, OCC advises you to put a ticket in and you never get a response.

Market Rate Survey - Childcare providers all across the state turned out in large numbers and did the 2024 Market Rate Survey, and the OCC is still not using the most recent data for subsidy rates, the understanding is that they have 30 days to collect and analyze the data and then implement it, this was done in 2021 when St. Louis City & County childcare providers were negatively impacted but this time they aren't using it, why?

Solutions:

The Office of Childhood needs to automatically renew child care subsidy applications until their new CCDS is fixed.

The Office of Childhood needs to automatically renew providers subsidy contracts until the new CCDS is fixed.

The Office of Childhood needs to pay child care providers on authorization/enrollment versus attendance until their CCDS system is fixed and they can pay providers on time, and the correct rates, instead of the burden of providers to do additional work to submit PPR's and wait months and months for payment.

For all the harm done to childcare providers there needs to be a stipend for the long hours, the stress on their bodies & minds, for the loans, the late fees, for all the debt and negative impact to their businesses. I have worked in childcare for 10+ years and this has been the most horrible experience.



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

			DATE: 9/10/2024	
COMMITTEE: Elementary and Secondary Education				
TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES				
WITNESS NAME				
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:				
WITNESS NAME: DEBORAH MANN			PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: EMMANUELSCHILDCARE.ORG			TITLE: EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR	
ADDRESS: 4736 PROSPECT AVE				
CITY: KANSAS CITY			STATE: MO	ZIP: 64130
		ATTENDANCE: Written	SUBMIT DATE: 9/5/2024 6:16 PM	
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.				

Emmanuel has struggled to maintain its operations as a result in payment shortages. Disproportionate, and accreditation rates being removed from my payments with no reason when we are still accredited and serving low income children. Reimbursement are delayed . Wait time to reach someone on the phone is hours and children authorizations not accessible



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

DATE:
9/10/2024

COMMITTEE:
Elementary and Secondary Education

TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES

WITNESS NAME

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:

WITNESS NAME:
DEIDRE ANDERSON-BARBEE

PHONE NUMBER:

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:
STARTING EARLY

TITLE:
EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR

ADDRESS:
3200 WAYNE AVE

CITY:
KANSAS CITY

STATE:
MO

ZIP:
64109

ATTENDANCE:
In-Person

SUBMIT DATE:
8/29/2024 3:47 PM

THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.

The childcare subsidy system has had longstanding challenges and has been poorly handled for many years. The change to the new vendor has only magnified the issues. As a result, there are many childcare providers across the state that are on the brink of closing their facilities as they were already hanging on by a thread. The staff are only marginally responsive and have failed to provide a consistent mechanism of two-way communication. Families that do not have access to consistent, affordable, safe and quality childcare are forced to make decisions that are adversely impacting their households. Starting Early is an organization that was recently formed to support providers and parents having a meaningful voice to ensure that the system in our state meets their needs. For more than 11 years I served as the CEO of EarlystART and operated high quality early childhood programs in the Kansas City area. I led the organization through growth and added two additional childcare centers allowing us to grow from serving 125 children to serving nearly 350 children. However, prior to my departure at the end of 2023, due to the ongoing challenges with staffing and slow payment through the subsidy system, we were forced to close 2 of the centers. It is imperative that we identify an emergency solution to the payment challenges while we work simultaneously on a long range solution that has an advanced technology system that optimizes payments. The burden of resolving the slow pay/no pay problems has resulted in countless hours spent waiting on hold, following up, and resubmitting paperwork that has already been submitted. No business that is not paid for services that are rendered can survive. It is my hope that an improved mechanism will be created for providers and families to submit their complaints and questions and that those issues will resolved more quickly. I also have a myriad of long term suggestions to make once we can come up with a short term solution to the problems.



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

COMMITTEE: Elementary and Secondary Education		DATE: 9/10/2024	
TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: DIAMOND HOUSTON		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS: 866 APT. 201 RIVER RUN COURT			
CITY: ST. LOUIS		STATE: MO	ZIP: 63137
		ATTENDANCE: Written	SUBMIT DATE: 9/9/2024 2:03 PM
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			

Issues since the Office of Childhood, under DESE took over childcare

October 2021 - Office of Childhood from the results of the Market Rate Survey (MRS) took 24-28% (depending on the area in MO) away from the childcare subsidy rate in the City & Counties of St. Louis. The decrease due to the MRS was devastating to providers, the OCC took 3 months to reverse the rate back to the original subsidy rate, leaving the city and counties of St. Louis did not get an increase after 3 years, but all rural areas of Missouri were given a rate increase of 24-28%. Let me repeat that so that it is clear, Rural areas of Missouri were given an increase while the city and counties of St. Louis were initially given a decrease and then put back at the base rate, therefore not receiving an increase yet again! The Office of Childhood sent out notification that providers would receive a change in their subsidy base rate, making sure to not say an increase or decrease, just saying there would be a rate change. In 2021, providers filled out a Market Rate Survey, the city and counties of St. Louis filled this survey out in error, due to the wording of the survey. The results of the survey caused St. Louis City and County providers to receive this decrease in their subsidy. Providers wrote to the Office of Childhood's Pamela Thomas, and the decrease was overturned due to this decrease being unlawful! The OCC promised to backdate the missing amounts, but many have not seen this refund as of today's date. The current MRS has not been implemented as of this date, what are the concerns? According to numerous sources the current MRS rates are high and being questioned, but when the rates were low (due to providers filling out the MRS incorrectly) and we were given a decrease no one questioned those results? To be clear, the current MRS was completed in April (2024) and we still don't have the results and it is still not being implemented because the provides rates are being questioned? So, when it is in their favor (OCC), not ours (providers) it is questioned, got it!

Pandemic funding - When looking at the OCC spend plan for ARPA funding, repeatedly priority was given to Rural areas, and the city & counties of St. Louis was excluded. Once again, disproportionately rural areas were given priority over the city & counties of St. Louis. There are owners in rural Missouri who started the pandemic with one childcare center and ended the pandemic with FOUR childcare centers...thanks to the disproportionate priority of grant funding given to rural areas...again, ONE owner now has FOUR childcares because of the priority given to rural areas!

June 2023 - MOPD new system - The OCC changed the previous Missouri Professional system for child care providers, and it was so poorly implemented that as of December 2023 providers still were not able to set up their accounts! There was little to no help, long wait times on the phone to get help, and the system still does not work correctly. And now that it has been a year, childcare educators now must

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MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

		DATE: 9/10/2024	
COMMITTEE: Elementary and Secondary Education			
TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:			
WITNESS NAME: DIANE CHAMBERLAIN		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: DESTINY LEARNING CENTER		TITLE: OWNER	
ADDRESS: 4914 PRAIRIE RIDGE STREET			
CITY: COLUMBIA		STATE: MO	ZIP: 65202
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:		SUBMIT DATE: 9/10/2024 12:00 AM
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

DATE:
9/10/2024

COMMITTEE:
Elementary and Secondary Education

TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES

WITNESS NAME

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:

WITNESS NAME:
DR. KARLA ESLINGER

PHONE NUMBER:

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:
DEPARTMENT OF ELEMENTARY AND SECONDARY EDUCATION

TITLE:
COMMISSIONER

ADDRESS:
205 JEFFERSON STREET, JEFFERSON STATE OFFICE BUILDING

CITY:
JEFFERSON CITY

STATE:
MO

ZIP:
65102

EMAIL:

ATTENDANCE:

SUBMIT DATE:
9/10/2024 12:00 AM

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MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
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		DATE: 9/10/2024	
COMMITTEE: Elementary and Secondary Education			
TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:			
WITNESS NAME: DR. PAM THOMAS		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: DEPARTMENT OF ELEMENTARY AND SECONDARY EDUCATION		TITLE: ASSISTANT COMMISSIONER	
ADDRESS: 205 JEFFERSON STREET, JEFFERSON STATE OFFICE BUILDING			
CITY: JEFFERSON CITY		STATE: MO	ZIP: 65102
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:		SUBMIT DATE: 9/10/2024 12:00 AM
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

			DATE: 9/10/2024	
COMMITTEE: Elementary and Secondary Education				
TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES				
WITNESS NAME				
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:				
WITNESS NAME: EDWIN HARRIS			PHONE NUMBER: 81-676-8260	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: PETER RABBIT LEARNING DEVELOPMENT CENTER/LITTLE BUNNIES LLC			TITLE: ADMINISTRATION	
ADDRESS: 3512 SOUTH 22ND STREET				
CITY: ST. JOSEPH			STATE: MO	ZIP: 64503
EMAIL:		ATTENDANCE:		SUBMIT DATE: 9/10/2024 12:00 AM
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.				



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

DATE:
9/10/2024

COMMITTEE:
Elementary and Secondary Education

TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES

WITNESS NAME

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:

WITNESS NAME:
GABRIELLE MOORE

PHONE NUMBER:

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:
TURN THE PAGE CDC

TITLE:
OWNER/DIRECTOR

ADDRESS:
205 HIGHVIEW AVE

CITY:
COLUMBIA

STATE:
MO

ZIP:
65202

ATTENDANCE:
In-Person

SUBMIT DATE:
9/10/2024 12:10 PM

THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.

Thank you for reaching out to us about the catastrophe that is happening with the childcare subsidy payments. We are a small to medium size center based in Columbia, Missouri that specifically serves families and households that fall well below the national poverty line. As a center we prioritize protective services children and are paired with Compass Health Network and their inpatient recovery programs to provide care for the children of families who struggle with addiction, mental health, and other life-changing events.

Our facility experienced delayed subsidy payments for December, January, and February, receiving them only in mid-February. However, these payments are incomplete, lacking accreditation, and disproportionate rates outlined in our Child Care Subsidy Contract with the Department of Elementary and Secondary Education.

Recently we have been just one weekend away from being forced to close our doors because of lack of funding and our inability to pay staff. To mitigate this financial strain, we were compelled to contact a bank officer and secure an additional line of personal credit using the business as collateral with an interest rate of 3.5% plus the prime rate. Obtaining this line of credit was crucial as it enabled us to sustain operations for a further period.

These delays have been putting additional stress on us because we are forced to juggle these problems while also running the business. My co-owner and I have spent numerous hours and days on the phone and computer trying to contact the proper people to submit our payment resolutions and to receive any communication of what additional information they may need to help expedite the process. Once we receive the invoices, we must go back and double-check that the numbers match up to the units of care that were submitted at the end of the month. If that information does not match, we must place another payment resolution in the system and even these corrective payments are not being completed properly or have little explanation for the payments. These hours and days spent handling DESE's job could have been used to help hire and educate our staff or implement a better curriculum in our classrooms.

In addition to causing a strain on the business, the new program is not efficient enough for our parents who do not have adequate capabilities to use, understand, and implement the parent side of the system. Internet access is not a guarantee when a lot of our enrolled families choose between their basic phone bills and electricity bills. Some of our parents do not understand how to navigate the new portal and will spend hours getting our assistance. The in-person offices they had used previously were taken away. Parents mainly use their phones for internet access and the software is not always compatible with these browsers. Applications are being closed out and delayed for longer periods of time because they cannot put in the information required.

We have also had many issues with the new payment system not communicating with the old CCBIS system. We have taken on new kids each month, including foster children, which many day cares in town will not take due to 'not profiting off of them'. However, these children are not in the old CCBIS system and thus we have not been paid for their attendance. Two of these foster children have been in attendance since February 1, 2024. Just one child's attendance for that amount of time would be \$6,816.00 As a business owner, I should be kicking these children out due to nonpayment. However, it is not the children's nor the foster parents' fault that the state has a huge system glitch that is preventing them from being paid out. If we did not take these children in, they would have limited options in Columbia and their parents would be unable to work.

We urge you to take action to address these issues and ensure that childcare subsidy payments are processed efficiently and consistently. The stability of our childcare facility and the well-being of the families we serve depend on it.



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

DATE:
9/10/2024

COMMITTEE:
Elementary and Secondary Education

TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES

WITNESS NAME

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:

WITNESS NAME:
JOCEYLN DONATI

PHONE NUMBER:

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:
LITTLE FEET BIG DREAMS CHILDCARE CENTER LLC

TITLE:
DIRECTOR

ADDRESS:
101 WEST NORMAL STREET

CITY:
IBERIA

STATE:
MO

ZIP:
65486

EMAIL:

ATTENDANCE:

SUBMIT DATE:
9/10/2024 12:00 AM

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COMMITTEE: Elementary and Secondary Education				
TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES				
WITNESS NAME				
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:				
WITNESS NAME: JULITA HARRIS			PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: PETER RABBIT LEARNING AND DEVELOPMENT CENTER/LITTLE BUNNIES LLC			TITLE: OWNER-DIRECTOR	
ADDRESS: 3512 AND 3508 SOUTH 22ND STREET				
CITY: ST. JOSEPH			STATE: MO	ZIP: 64503
EMAIL:		ATTENDANCE:		SUBMIT DATE: 9/10/2024 12:00 AM
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TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:			
WITNESS NAME: KARI MONSEES		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: DEPARTMENT OF ELEMENTARY AND SECONDARY EDUCATION		TITLE: DEPUTY COMMISSIONER	
ADDRESS: 205 JEFFERSON STREET, JEFFERSON STATE OFFICE BUILDING			
CITY: JEFFERSON CITY		STATE: MO	ZIP: 65102
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:		SUBMIT DATE: 9/10/2024 12:00 AM
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WITNESS NAME

INDIVIDUAL:

WITNESS NAME:
KEENA DURHAM

PHONE NUMBER:

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:

TITLE:

ADDRESS:
5720 PARK LANE

CITY:
ST. LOUIS

STATE:
MO

ZIP:
63147

ATTENDANCE:
Written

SUBMIT DATE:
9/9/2024 2:04 PM

THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.

Issues since the Office of Childhood, under DESE took over childcare

October 2021 - Office of Childhood from the results of the Market Rate Survey (MRS) took 24-28% (depending on the area in MO) away from the childcare subsidy rate in the City & Counties of St. Louis. The decrease due to the MRS was devastating to providers, the OCC took 3 months to reverse the rate back to the original subsidy rate, leaving the city and counties of St. Louis did not get an increase after 3 years, but all rural areas of Missouri were given a rate increase of 24-28%. Let me repeat that so that it is clear, Rural areas of Missouri were given an increase while the city and counties of St. Louis were initially given a decrease and then put back at the base rate, therefore not receiving an increase yet again! The Office of Childhood sent out notification that providers would receive a change in their subsidy base rate, making sure to not say an increase or decrease, just saying there would be a rate change. In 2021, providers filled out a Market Rate Survey, the city and counties of St. Louis filled this survey out in error, due to the wording of the survey. The results of the survey caused St. Louis City and County providers to receive this decrease in their subsidy. Providers wrote to the Office of Childhood's Pamela Thomas, and the decrease was overturned due to this decrease being unlawful! The OCC promised to backdate the missing amounts, but many have not seen this refund as of today's date. The current MRS has not been implemented as of this date, what are the concerns? According to numerous sources the current MRS rates are high and being questioned, but when the rates were low (due to providers filling out the MRS incorrectly) and we were given a decrease no one questioned those results? To be clear, the current MRS was completed in April (2024) and we still don't have the results and it is still not being implemented because the provides rates are being questioned? So, when it is in their favor (OCC), not ours (providers) it is questioned, got it!

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go into the system and renew it, while the system is difficult to navigate and still so many are struggling, an ENTIRE year later. It is taking months “renew your membership”. The system doesn’t transfer all the Professional Development, and when you try to upload a certificate, it will not save the certificate. What is the point of the system if it is not tracking your PD?

September 2023 -

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As you are very aware MO subsidy payment stays federally ranked the lowest in the county and that such a major budget cut of 20% (in less than three weeks) resulted in devastating budget cuts, such as:

- Laying off experienced and/or degreed teachers,
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Therefore, cutting our already mediocre budget by 20% was beyond survival for many MO. Accredited childcare centers. The direct work of MO accredited centers in low-income areas of the State that ensures highly effective childcare is a win for all Missourians, and when it was taken away, it was and remains devastating to children.

The state plan states you can receive both the 20% and/or the 30% enhancements if you qualify for one or both enhancements, yet the OOC stated, “why should some get these enhancements and not everyone” (Pam Thomas). The enhancements were set up so more providers would accept child care subsidy (30% disproportionate share, providers care for 50% or more subsidized children), Accreditation enhancement was to help bring quality to Missouri since we don’t have a quality rating system (20% accreditation share, providers are accredited programs). It is worth noting that there are other enhancements as well, but the OCC decided that these two could not be “stacked”.

October 2023 - OCC took 20% away from childcare providers that were both accredited and receiving the disproportionate share, the disproportionate share is an enhancement given to providers that provide care to at least 50% of their licensed capacity subsidized care. These providers provide care in the most underserved areas, these are the families that live below the poverty line and are receiving subsidy services. The providers are also the largest number of accredited centers in the state...to make this clearer, the providers that are serving the most underserved population are also the childcare centers that are offering the highest quality of care (accredited centers) were the centers that the Office of Childhood under the direction of Pamela Thomas were given a reduction 20% in their funding! This is once again, disproportionately in the Cities and Counties of St. Louis.

December 2023 - New Child Care Subsidy System

Parent issues -

No training was given to parents prior to a brand-new system being implemented for them to apply for child care subsidies.

In order to apply for child care subsidy, you would need the internet, a computer or a smartphone, therefore there was not equitable access to the new system, to apply for child care subsidy.

Parents are currently waiting months (60-90 days) for their childcare to be approved and then months for them to be authorized to their childcare provider. How are parents expected to wait for months?

They are losing their jobs, their children are going without, this has been such a hardship for the entire

family. And most importantly, CHILDREN ARE BEING LEFT IN UNSAFE SPACES!!!! Since we already have spaces for the families to go to apply for child care subsidies and other services, why can't we set these up as satellite offices to assist families that do not have access to the internet, computers and smartphones? Why was this not an option?

Provider issues - Providers continue to lose money due to not being paid on time, the correct amount, and must do the extra work such as Provider Payment Resolution forms. And because they are so backlogged it takes months. Providers do not receive emails once something is received, that something is needed in the new child care data system, or when something is submitted in ProMo, why do providers have to go into each system several times a day to see if there are notifications when an email would alert us to this. Providers have extremely long hold times on the phones....

January 2024 -New Child Care Data System issues - the new childcare data system has not worked for the past 9+ months, the staff in the office of childcare are not able to properly implement this system, they literally did not test the system to make sure it paid providers correctly. The OCC does not have any answers, they just ask for patience, after 9 months of being patient...childcares are closing due to not being paid on time or the correct amount for 9 months! Many providers are taking out loans, they are working long hours without pay so they can pay staff, they are cutting quality programming and staff. This system has been a nightmare, with many, many issues. Providers must upload renewal paperwork into the system and the renewals are not coming through, their words, "there is a glitch" and so many contracts are not being renewed, if you cannot renew your contract, you cannot accept subsidy children. It's the same for anything you must upload, there are "glitches" and so nothing is working properly. As of today, August 30th this system still is not operating correctly, and providers cannot get their child care subsidy contract renewed! Providers are on hold for hours, trying to speak with someone. The ticketing system does not work, OCC advises you to put a ticket in and you never get a response.

Market Rate Survey - Childcare providers all across the state turned out in large numbers and did the 2024 Market Rate Survey, and the OCC is still not using the most recent data for subsidy rates, the understanding is that they have 30 days to collect and analyze the data and then implement it, this was done in 2021 when St. Louis City & County childcare providers were negatively impacted but this time they aren't using it, why?

Solutions:

The Office of Childhood needs to automatically renew child care subsidy applications until their new CCDS is fixed.

The Office of Childhood needs to automatically renew providers subsidy contracts until the new CCDS is fixed.

The Office of Childhood needs to pay child care providers on authorization/enrollment versus attendance until their CCDS system is fixed and they can pay providers on time, and the correct rates, instead of the burden of providers to do additional work to submit PPR's and wait months and months for payment.

For all the harm done to childcare providers there needs to be a stipend for the long hours, the stress on their bodies & minds, for the loans, the late fees, for all the debt and negative impact to their businesses. I all the years I have worked in childcare this has been the most horrible experience ever.



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

DATE:
9/10/2024

COMMITTEE:
Elementary and Secondary Education

TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES

WITNESS NAME

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:

WITNESS NAME:
LACEY ALLEN

PHONE NUMBER:

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:
LEARNING AND FUN PRESCHOOL

TITLE:
OWNER

ADDRESS:
6007 SWOPE PARKWAY

CITY:
KANSAS CITY

STATE:
MO

ZIP:
64130

ATTENDANCE:
In-Person

SUBMIT DATE:
9/6/2024 4:49 PM

THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.

To the Representatives of the Missouri House,
I am writing today in hopes to share a little bit of our story as it relates to the subsidy crisis in Missouri. I am the owner of Learning and Fun Preschool, in the heart of Kansas City. I would like to give you a small snapshot of who we are so you may better understand the need for help.
Our center was founded in 1976 and since that time has provided care and early education for the children in our community. We are a licensed, accredited, subsidy provider and are licensed for 108 children. Our enrollment has always been made up of about 90% subsidy families. Our goal is to provide top quality care and early education for the children IN our community, where most qualify for state assistance. This means very few families that we serve are private pay.
I have been the owner for over 9 years, and I have seen our fair share of challenges, but none have concerned me quite like our current situation. We began noticing issues in January when DESE rolled out the new system. I was shocked to see that my payments were substantially less than I expected, and I soon realized that I wasn't being paid for rate enhancements that I'd always qualified for and received (i.e. an additional 20% for accreditation, and an additional 30% for disproportionate share). I reported it through the DESE Subsidy payment line but was advised to just submit a payment resolution form, for every child, for every month that we were paid incorrectly for. In April, after not seeing any results from my requests, I called again and found out that DESE didn't show us as an accredited facility, or that we were eligible for disproportionate share. The rep I spoke with put in a request and on May 28th I received an email stating that after some digging, they found out that during the system change in December, my rate enhancement did not carry over. They stated that they had corrected the issue and added it into CCDS so that May attendance would pay out correctly. They also stated that our center had been added to the list to receive back pay from December through April (even though my payments were wrong for children receiving care in November too).
However, when I received my payment for May, it still wasn't correct. I did receive my 20% enhancement for accreditation, but only 10% for disproportionate share. Every month, it continues to be wrong.
I have made multiple phone calls, where the call center representatives might be kind, but they are uninformed. I rarely get a representative who knows any answer to my questions. I have sent multiple emails to the DESE payment division and have never received responses. Recently (the beginning of August) I had a call center representative tell me they were escalating my request because of the amount of backpay that I was due. She said a representative should be reaching out to me soon, maybe within a week or two. It's been over a month since that call, and I've not heard anything.
As of today, I have not received a correct payment since DESE took over, nor have I received ANY back pay. In addition, every payment resolution I have submitted has been unresolved.

Currently, I am owed over \$103,000 in backpay solely due to the rate enhancements I have not received since January.

I would add that the remittances are done in a way that makes it extremely hard to reconcile a payment. Most times the invoice amount is different than the payment amount by anywhere from a few cents to over thousands of dollars. In the last two months, I have been shorted nearly \$4,000 from what DESE said I SHOULD have been paid, to what was actually paid. This is a separate issue from my rate enhancements. This is a bookkeeping nightmare and leaves me feeling like it's nearly impossible to keep proper records when I can't understand how they figured the payment total.

That brings the total that I am owed to over \$107,000 in backpay.

I'm sure I don't need to tell you that this has had a huge impact on my business. I am quickly burning through any reserve I had and if things aren't corrected quickly, I will soon be at the point of making some very hard decisions. I personally have to work another job in addition to this to help make ends meet and to continue to fund business operations.

I have a dedicated staff of 13 amazing people that show up day after day because they love what they do. They are a gift to the community, to the children and to the families we serve. I shouldn't have to worry about how I'm going to pay them, but I feel like we are being forced to make a decision between these children and our business, and quite frankly, that's wrong, it's unethical, and it goes against everything those of us in the early childhood field are here for.

After almost 10 years as a business owner, I have fought so hard to have a financially sound, healthy and viable business. In just a matter of months the state of Missouri has flipped things upside down and I am extremely concerned at the possible outcome that this crisis is rapidly forcing us toward.

We all know that childcare is a highly regulated industry, and providers are held to very high standards and expectations, but I cannot accept that the state is not held to those same standards and expectations. You are sitting on funds that are owed to us, while center after center closes its doors because they have not been paid the money that is due to them.

While we fight and spend countless hours trying to get paid for what is rightly owed to us, DESE continues to make hollow promises with no results.

Why is there is no mention of us receiving interest and penalty fees when the state owes its providers money? I can be sure that should I not be able to pay my taxes on time due to the fact that the state owes me well over \$100,000, I will absolutely be assessed interest and penalties and will be expected to pay them.

The impact this has on families is also significant. We have many families in our center that are trying to get reapproved but the amount of time it takes for the approval is substantial which puts undue strain in the home. This forces parents to find alternative care for their children or requires them to miss work or school, quit jobs, etc.

How can this go on any longer? I beg you for a solution. We need funding and we need to see action immediately, before one more center has to close, or before one more child is denied an opportunity for safe, quality care and education.

Thank you for your time.

Lacey Allen
Owner
Learning and Fun Preschool



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

			DATE: 9/10/2024	
COMMITTEE: Elementary and Secondary Education				
TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES				
WITNESS NAME				
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:				
WITNESS NAME: LASHUNDA LANE-GLASGOW			PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: A GALAXY OF STARS CHILD CARE			TITLE: DIRECTOR	
ADDRESS: 1626 TOWNE DRIVE				
CITY: COLUMBIA			STATE: MO	ZIP: 65205
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:		SUBMIT DATE: 9/10/2024 12:00 AM	
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.				



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DATE:
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COMMITTEE:
Elementary and Secondary Education

TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES

WITNESS NAME

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:

WITNESS NAME:
LATONYA WILLIAMS

PHONE NUMBER:

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:
BARTLETT CENTER

TITLE:
EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR

ADDRESS:
409 S. 18TH ST.

CITY:
ST. JOSEPH

STATE:
MO

ZIP:
64506

ATTENDANCE:
In-Person

SUBMIT DATE:
9/4/2024 11:50 AM

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My name is LaTonya Williams, and I am the Executive Director of Bartlett Center, a community center located in midtown St., Joseph. The Bartlett Center is a nonprofit, 501c3 organization, United Way partner and contracted by the State of Missouri to provide social programs to the community. Bartlett Center is not just another childcare or afterschool program. Our programs are unique because we are designed to handle trauma- focused cognitive behavior therapy, which evidence-based treatment for children and adolescents impacted by trauma. This therapy, along with Adverse Childhood Experiences training (ACEs) allows our program to help our community grow and raise healthy children.

We are comprised of three components: a childcare that has a daycare and a preschool, a youth program that has before/after school as well as day camps when there is no school, and a community outreach program that involves workshops for the parents as well as extracurricular activities for the community.

Our childcare clients are working parents who need educational opportunities for their children so they will be kindergarten ready. 96% of the children in this program are from low-income families of working parents who receive some state assistance, which is where the problems lie.

Since the beginning of 2020 when KinderConnect first was rolled out, due to the many issues with the program, Bartlett Center has lost an average of \$80K each year and it's growing each month. This is based upon past year's childcare subsidy revenues and our current revenues, as well as an extra audit in 2022. It's not only the loss of revenues, but also the inconsistency of the payments, the lack of approving applicants, the issues with KinderConnect, the many mistakes that extend from the minute to the largest issues at hand.

It's this simple- my program is dying a painful death due to the problems with the state. My program doesn't deserve this, my community doesn't deserve this, but more importantly, my employees, my parents and my children don't deserve this. My children are among the children that other centers either kick out or refuse to even take in. We love and care for these children, as well as teach them to cope with their traumas, as well as their triggers. All of our employees are enrolled in an educational program of some sort, and we accommodate their schedules in order to support them to be able to grow and move on from the BC to provide better for their families. We do so much for so many people- we change lives.

As I type this, we have less than \$11K in our bank accounts. Payday is September 15th and I don't know where those funds will come from. We are currently owed subsidy payments from May on- but please understand that we have never been fully paid out from those previous months, for years (besides the months where we were paid based on enrollment). My days are spent trying to find people who can help us as well as looking for other sources of funding, my nights are sleepless. I'm not only

afraid that through no fault of ours, our doors will close, but that my employees will no longer have a workplace that supports their growth and that our children will no longer have a place where they can learn, grow and thrive.

Simply put, I'm terrified. I'm willing to do any and everything I need to do to save my center.

What can we do? Who can help us?



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TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:			
WITNESS NAME: LINDA DIANE COLEMAN		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: PATRICK ENTERPRISES, LLC DBA NANNY's EARLY LEARNING CENTER		TITLE: OWNER	
ADDRESS: 404 MCBAINE AVE			
CITY: COLUMBIA		STATE: MO	ZIP: 65203
		ATTENDANCE: In-Person	SUBMIT DATE: 9/10/2024 11:01 AM
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			

September 10, 2024
Missouri House of Representatives
Missouri Department of Elementary and Secondary Education

Ladies and Gentlemen,

I am here today because the changes made by DESE has affected my Childcare Center in an extremely negative way. I truly believe that DESE had good intentions to improve on the old system, but unfortunately, they took a functioning system and turned it into a nightmare. Today, I am only seeking a resolution to the situation in a timely and effective manner.

The major changes have impacted so many people, the parents, the childcare providers and the employees at the childcare centers who cannot be paid without the money owed by DESE. Parents are no longer able to receive childcare services that allows for them to remain working. DESE made the choice to go "live" with a new program that parents are not able to use effectively and unfortunately has caused so many catastrophes on so many levels.

First off, all parents do not have access to a computer, so therefore that is the first major mistake. No longer are parents able to walk into a brick and mortar building and talk to and receive assistance from an individual. The parents that do have computers are not able to navigate through the many channels, upload documents and correspond in a timely fashion when the only line of communication is via email. Parents that attempt to call into the system have to wait for hours only to be told that their application will be processed in the order that it was received.

In the meantime, parents are unable to work if the childcare center will not accept the parents saying that they have applied for childcare assistance but are waiting on DESE to respond. Childcare providers are then being placed in a situation of hoping that DESE will go back and pay for care that has already been provided, sometimes it takes over four months to get the approval. Who can rightfully work for four months without being paid? Add to that, many of the children that have been approved, their DCN number will not merge with the new system, (after 6 months and counting) why should this really be a problem? Who is managing the "IT" department that is incapable of merging the two systems effectively after so many months. Providers are not being paid correctly and their only repercussion is to complete a Payment Resolution Request and then wait many months to be told that extra staff has been hired to assist with processing the requests. How can they assist with something that they no nothing about?

At this point DESE needs to allow Providers who understand how the system should work, to explain things from our perspective and arrive at a solution together. Instead of questioning anyone's PRR, at

this time DESE should be approving every request and pay it immediately. But instead, I am spending countless hours going over every payment each month, making a list of students that I did not receive payment for, then filling out the PRR, and trying to keep track of if or when DESE responds to the request and approves it. If DESE does not approve it then I have to again reach out to the person who has no understanding of how the childcare system works, and plead my case to be paid for work that I have already done. This is unacceptable for any business to operate at this poor quality. But to say that our State Office is allowing such behavior is even worse. We should not have to leave our centers and come to the State Capital to demand that we be paid for something that we rightfully earned.

Over 50 % of the children enrolled at my facility receive state assistance. I never want to turn away a parent who is already struggling in today's economy and trying to navigate through the unnecessary changes that DESE has placed on them. We as a State, should be making things easier for these families, not harder. The stress of not knowing if your child will be accepted at their daycare, because the provider is not being paid, is hard to fathom. Why is this even being allowed? More so, why has this been okay for so many people for so long? Who is really to blame for this disaster? Everyone here today should be appalled to say that no one made an effort to step in sooner.

Too many Childcare Centers have had to close their doors due to this debacle. Not to mention the many providers who have taken out personal loans with interest. Is DESE going to be held accountable for paying the interest that the providers are being charged?

Does DESE plan to pay interest on the money that they withheld from the providers for all of these months?

This letter is not about pointing fingers so much as it is to get everyone to understand the magnitude of the situation. We are here today to seek a resolution to the situation, in a timely and effective manner.

Thank you for your time today

Sincerely,

Diane Coleman, Owner

Nanny's Early Learning Center

404 McBaine Ave

Columbia, MO, 65203



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

COMMITTEE: Elementary and Secondary Education		DATE: 9/10/2024	
TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: LISA M SCHEER		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS: 3548 ALBERHILL DRIVE			
CITY: SAINT LOUIS		STATE: MO	ZIP: 63129
ATTENDANCE: In-Person		SUBMIT DATE: 9/9/2024 1:48 PM	
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			

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Therefore, cutting our already mediocre budget by 20% was beyond survival for many MO. Accredited childcare centers. The direct work of MO accredited centers in low-income areas of the State that ensures highly effective childcare is a win for all Missourians, and when it was taken away, it was and remains devastating to children.

The state plan states you can receive both the 20% and/or the 30% enhancements if you qualify for one or both enhancements, yet the OOC stated, “why should some get these enhancements and not everyone” (Pam Thomas). The enhancements were set up so more providers would accept child care subsidy (30% disproportionate share, providers care for 50% or more subsidized children), Accreditation enhancement was to help bring quality to Missouri since we don’t have a quality rating system (20% accreditation share, providers are accredited programs). It is worth noting that there are other enhancements as well, but the OCC decided that these two could not be “stacked”.

October 2023 - OCC took 20% away from childcare providers that were both accredited and receiving the disproportionate share, the disproportionate share is an enhancement given to providers that provide care to at least 50% of their licensed capacity subsidized care. These providers provide care in the most underserved areas, these are the families that live below the poverty line and are receiving subsidy services. The providers are also the largest number of accredited centers in the state...to make this clearer, the providers that are serving the most underserved population are also the childcare centers that are offering the highest quality of care (accredited centers) were the centers that the Office of Childhood under the direction of Pamela Thomas were given a reduction 20% in their funding! This is once again, disproportionately in the Cities and Counties of St. Louis.

December 2023 - New Child Care Subsidy System

Parent issues -

No training was given to parents prior to a brand-new system being implemented for them to apply for child care subsidies.

In order to apply for child care subsidy, you would need the internet, a computer or a smartphone, therefore there was not equitable access to the new system, to apply for child care subsidy.

Parents are currently waiting months (60-90 days) for their childcare to be approved and then months for them to be authorized to their childcare provider. How are parents expected to wait for months?

They are losing their jobs, their children are going without, this has been such a hardship for the entire

family. And most importantly, CHILDREN ARE BEING LEFT IN UNSAFE SPACES!!!! Since we already have spaces for the families to go to apply for child care subsidies and other services, why can't we set these up as satellite offices to assist families that do not have access to the internet, computers and smartphones? Why was this not an option?

Provider issues - Providers continue to lose money due to not being paid on time, the correct amount, and must do the extra work such as Provider Payment Resolution forms. And because they are so backlogged it takes months. Providers do not receive emails once something is received, that something is needed in the new child care data system, or when something is submitted in ProMo, why do providers have to go into each system several times a day to see if there are notifications when an email would alert us to this. Providers have extremely long hold times on the phones....

January 2024 -New Child Care Data System issues - the new childcare data system has not worked for the past 9+ months, the staff in the office of childcare are not able to properly implement this system, they literally did not test the system to make sure it paid providers correctly. The OCC does not have any answers, they just ask for patience, after 9 months of being patient...childcares are closing due to not being paid on time or the correct amount for 9 months! Many providers are taking out loans, they are working long hours without pay so they can pay staff, they are cutting quality programming and staff. This system has been a nightmare, with many, many issues. Providers must upload renewal paperwork into the system and the renewals are not coming through, their words, "there is a glitch" and so many contracts are not being renewed, if you cannot renew your contract, you cannot accept subsidy children. It's the same for anything you must upload, there are "glitches" and so nothing is working properly. As of today, August 30th this system still is not operating correctly, and providers cannot get their child care subsidy contract renewed! Providers are on hold for hours, trying to speak with someone. The ticketing system does not work, OOC advises you to put a ticket in and you never get a response.

Market Rate Survey - Childcare providers all across the state turned out in large numbers and did the 2024 Market Rate Survey, and the OCC is still not using the most recent data for subsidy rates, the understanding is that they have 30 days to collect and analyze the data and then implement it, this was done in 2021 when St. Louis City & County childcare providers were negatively impacted but this time they aren't using it, why?

Solutions:

The Office of Childhood needs to automatically renew child care subsidy applications until their new CCDS is fixed.

The Office of Childhood needs to automatically renew providers subsidy contracts until the new CCDS is fixed.

The Office of Childhood needs to pay child care providers on authorization/enrollment versus attendance until their CCDS system is fixed and they can pay providers on time, and the correct rates, instead of the burden of providers to do additional work to submit PPR's and wait months and months for payment.

For all the harm done to childcare providers there needs to be a stipend for the long hours, the stress on their bodies & minds, for the loans, the late fees, for all the debt and negative impact to their businesses. I have worked in childcare for 30+ years and this has been horrible.



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

			DATE: 9/10/2024	
COMMITTEE: Elementary and Secondary Education				
TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES				
WITNESS NAME				
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:				
WITNESS NAME: LYNDSEY ELLIOTT			PHONE NUMBER: 573-308-554	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:			TITLE:	
ADDRESS:				
CITY:			STATE: MO	ZIP:
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:		SUBMIT DATE: 9/10/2024 12:00 AM	
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TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES				
WITNESS NAME				
INDIVIDUAL:				
WITNESS NAME: MARY CROCKETT SMITH			PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:			TITLE:	
ADDRESS:				
CITY:			STATE: MO	ZIP:
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:		SUBMIT DATE: 9/10/2024 12:00 AM	
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Elementary and Secondary Education

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WITNESS NAME

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:

WITNESS NAME:
MEGAN HUFFMAN

PHONE NUMBER:

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:
RISING SUN LEARNING CENTER

TITLE:
PROGRAM OWNER

ADDRESS:
1170 W 103RD ST

CITY:
KANSAS CITY, MO

STATE:
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ZIP:
64114

ATTENDANCE:
In-Person

SUBMIT DATE:
9/9/2024 11:52 AM

THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.

I am the owner of a childcare center in Kansas City, MO serving around 35% subsidized families. I have run this program for nearly a decade and have always been the one over subsidy. As a former foster care case manager in Jackson County, I understand the need for subsidy-contracted providers. I am committed to serving subsidized families, no matter the red tape. I was involved in the advisory meetings before the new CCBS system rolled out and have been encouraging my fellow providers to stick with subsidy, even during times when it has been a struggle.

The transition to the CCBS system has been less than perfect for sure. There have been multiple times when an authorization was not entered correctly and I reached out to OOC for assistance. I do have a couple of small invoices that I have not yet received payment for, but I am mostly whole regarding my subsidy payments as of today. This is also a relatively short-term issue since the feds have mandated that states move to payment by authorization over attendance which will significantly simplify the payment process in the near future.

I wanted to make sure that both sides of this issue are being heard. Yes, the CCBS system has had its struggles and I have had to double-check payments each month to make sure that everything is being paid as it should. There have been issues each month that I have had to reach out to get fixed.

Examples of the impediments I have encountered include:

- CCBS showing an active authorization while KinderConnect does not show an active authorization. This means that I am unable to submit attendance data for that child
- Authorizations getting stuck somewhere along the way between application and authorization
- Parents having started multiple applications due to not being able to see the previously started application which lead to their authorization being delayed
- A child not appearing on the remittance for payment when attendance data had been submitted and accepted along with the other students

With each issue I encountered, I reached out to OOC and was met with quick responses and solutions within a few business days.

There were many years when I felt like I was screaming into the wind when trying to get subsidy issues fixed and I have taken the time to make connections within DESE and OOC so that I am able to send feedback to those with the power to improve providers' experience. I have shared these contacts with more providers than I can begin to count and they have found solutions to their issues.

In order to continue to improve the experience of subsidy-contracted providers, Missouri needs to provide the following:

- More call center workers to shorten wait times. Neither parents nor providers have the time and ability to sit on hold for hours at a time.

- Better training for call center workers so they have the knowledge and the power to actually fix the issue in question once you actually reach a person.
- A clear path to next-level help when the entry-level call center person is unable to fix your issue
- Prioritize moving to pay by authorization over attendance. This would simplify the process and bring Missouri in compliance with federal mandates.

I am not an IT professional, and I do not pretend to have an understanding of the underlying computer system and its struggles. What I DO know is that since Pam Thomas was given the reigns at OOC, I have felt heard for the first time in a decade. She understands the struggles of Missouri's early education field and genuinely wants to improve the experience of providers. She is not the type of bureaucratic leader who gives a nickel and tells us to be grateful for what we get (the message received by providers pre-OOC). She acknowledges her department's shortcomings while working tirelessly to improve the future for Missouri's childcare providers. I have routinely received responses from Ms. Thomas to my emails well outside of business hours, some even in the middle of the night and over holiday breaks.

We all acknowledge that Missouri's childcare subsidy system needs help. So it is the responsibility of the State to provide additional resources until such a time that the system is fully functional. Removing resources, including and especially a leader who is humble enough to acknowledge that there is more work to be done, will NOT solve providers' struggles – that approach will add gas to this fire.

I would also like to mention that I also own a center in Kansas, giving me a unique perspective on the different ways that each state supports its providers. Kansas has been paying by authorization for years and their system is much simpler. However, Missouri has blown Kansas completely out of the water when it comes to childcare relief funds. We have not received any such support in Kansas for over 2 years as compared to the multitude of funding opportunities provided to childcare by Missouri. I am most grateful for the Retention Bonus program as it helped me complete in a difficult labor market and kept my teachers afloat in their personal finances. Please consider continuing this impactful program!

For many years I have been raising my hand to volunteer to do things like testify in applicable committees or answer any questions that members of this body may have about our field and our needs. I am willing to meet in person, via zoom, or simply take a phone call at your convenience. I hope and believe that most members of this body want to make decisions that will actually improve lives of providers, but that cannot be accomplished without including front-line providers in such decisions.



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DATE:
9/10/2024

COMMITTEE:
Elementary and Secondary Education

TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES

WITNESS NAME

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:

WITNESS NAME:
PAUL PREVO

PHONE NUMBER:

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:
TIGER TOTS PRESCHOOLS

TITLE:
OWNER

ADDRESS:
1609 PARIS RD SUITE 101

CITY:
COLUMBIA

STATE:
MO

ZIP:
65201

ATTENDANCE:
In-Person

SUBMIT DATE:
9/9/2024 5:05 PM

THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.

Tiger Tots Preschools is the largest private provider of early childhood education services within 100+ miles of Columbia and Jefferson City. We currently have outstanding invoices due from DESE of approximately \$110,000-\$120,000 dating back to Jan 2024. This does not include July and August. In addition, our families receiving subsidy are averaging a 50% rejection rate upon RENEWAL due to the complications of renewing applications on a cell phone. After 18 years, we have never felt like giving up on helping to develop confident, capable students for success, even during Covid, until this year due to the frustrations of this situation for our families and our centers. We have several proposals to address some of the root causes of frustration for our families and providers across the state. Here are a few of our ideas:

- 1- Automatic provisional approval for up to 90 days. Guardians and current providers need to both be able to see the status of the application and both should be notified when items are needed so providers can assist families in keeping their subsidy and being able to be a part of the workforce.
- 2- Integration of the approval process for child care subsidy, Medicaid, food assistance and other governmental programs. Many families receiving subsidy are hard working individuals that do not have the time or may lack the understanding of a complicated process involving multiple systems, requirements and deadlines.
- 3- Should a guardian lose employment, the state should allow full-time coverage for up to 6 weeks to allow that individual to have time to apply and interview for new employment opportunities.
- 4- Unless otherwise stated by a guardian or parent, renewing subsidy to stay with the same center should not require them to submit the same provider's DVN number. That information should automatically roll over, decreasing the likelihood of a delay or mis-entry.
- 5- If a provider has uploaded all attendance and necessary information to the state, the state should be required to pay in full for the submission within 60 days. If underpayment occurs for some reason, additional funds can be added to the next scheduled payment. If overpayment occurs, it can be deducted from the next scheduled payment.
- 6- If the state is unable to approve/decline childcare subsidy for a family the family should receive an automatic extension assuming all necessary documentation was submitted in a timely manner. Additionally, if a family submits everything as early as possible in the process the state should ensure current subsidy does not end before the renewed period begins.

These are a few of our ideas for making the process simple, addressing on time payments to providers, and increasing the number of spaces available statewide so our families may be a part of the workforce.

Thank you for your time and consideration. I look forward to speaking at the Sept 10th hearing and answering any questions that I can.

**Paul Prevo, Owner
Tiger Tots Preschools
Columbia, MO**



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WITNESS NAME

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:

WITNESS NAME:
PAULA A STALLINGS

PHONE NUMBER:

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:
STEPPING STONES PRESCHOOL

TITLE:
OWNER

ADDRESS:
297 MAJOR TERRACE

CITY:
HOLTS SUMMIT

STATE:
MO

ZIP:
65043

ATTENDANCE:
Written

SUBMIT DATE:
8/30/2024 6:56 AM

THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.

Hello my name is Paula Stallings. I am the owner of Stepping Stones Preschool, Stepping Stones Infant Care and Capitol Kids Development Center. I have been in a childcare provider for 12 1/2 years. I have complied with all the rules for each part of the subsidy program that is required. Starting back to November 2023 I didn't receive a subsidy payment for Stepping Stones Preschool. This would have been an invoice date of 12/1/2023 when the new Childcare Data System rolled out. I received that subsidy payment in March 2024. Luckily at that time I was able to pay the bills, staff and myself. Right now I am owed many months for a few children and full months on all. We trusted that this new system would be the beginning of a new era in a way that would be positive. Instead, it has been a burden most anyone that expects subsidy. I have emailed multiple times with no email back or an email that they are working on getting the backlog taken care of. I have sat on the phone for hours doing errands because it took 3 hours or more to get someone on the phone to speak with. Once on the phone then the person either didn't know what to do or just spoke to get you off of the phone with no results. The call center staff are not able to do anything with any of the information but escalate it. An escalation doesn't do much for anyone but get the provider off of the phone so they can move on to the next person. It is frustrating to know that no matter the time you spend on getting your part done that subsidies part wouldn't be done in a timely manner. I was told that if I sent a Payment resolution in to CCDS that they would just throw them away. I was told that multiple times. I also sent in many tickets to get the information looked at so that I would have payments coming in. I found that if I sent one in sometimes, I would have a response within 5 minutes. The results were that the ticket was resolved. This is for one center. This doesn't include the other two centers. I won't go into those because it is redundant. What I do know is I love what I do for a job every day, not receiving payments from a so-called trusted entity should not ever be a problem but here we are!



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WITNESS NAME

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:

WITNESS NAME:
RACHEL WILFLEY

PHONE NUMBER:

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:
KINDERCARE LEARNING COMPANIES

TITLE:
DISTRICT LEADER

ADDRESS:
3760 N JACKSON AVE

CITY:
KANSAS CITY

STATE:
MO

ZIP:
64117

ATTENDANCE:
In-Person

SUBMIT DATE:
9/9/2024 3:02 PM

THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.

In Missouri, KinderCare Learning Companies (KinderCare) proudly operates 23 early learning centers, serving just over 2,000 children. KinderCare is committed to providing all children with high-quality care, regardless of family income. Moreover, 36% of the children enrolled in our centers participate in the Missouri State Subsidy Program.

KinderCare's testimony will help draw attention to the barriers children, families, and providers face in Missouri. Current subsidy challenges fall into three primary categories, including: technology, delays in family approval, and inaccurate payments.

1. Technology related challenges | KinderCare recommends: (1) Allow child care providers to manually adjust attendance each month to ensure that full and accurate payment for care provided is received; (2) Ensure both Android and iOS operating systems support swipe activities via the portal; and (3) Upgrade state issued tablets and ensure one working tablet is available for every 30 children per center.

2. Backlog of subsidy applications leading to significant delays in initial authorization and reauthorization | KinderCare recommends: (1) Swiftly work to eliminate the backlog of subsidy applications—prioritizing renewals followed by new authorizations—to ensure families are authorized within 30-days; and (2) Support child care providers with continued payment during the redetermination period so families are not forced to disenroll.

3. Accounting inaccuracies leading to over, under, and missed subsidy payments | KinderCare recommends: Reduce and promptly rectify payment inaccuracies and ensure moving forward all providers receive subsidy reimbursements in a timely fashion with a significant reduction in payment errors.

Thank you to the committee for hosting this informational hearing and exploring the ongoing child care subsidy challenges. Please view KinderCare as a partner, committed to providing high-quality child care and early learning programs and supporting working families throughout Missouri.



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Elementary and Secondary Education

TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES

WITNESS NAME

INDIVIDUAL:

WITNESS NAME:
SAMANTHA CROSS

PHONE NUMBER:

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:

TITLE:

ADDRESS:
3129 CHIPPEWA ST

CITY:
SAINT LOUIS

STATE:
MO

ZIP:
63118

ATTENDANCE:
In-Person

SUBMIT DATE:
9/9/2024 3:40 PM

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Protective Service children and foster & Adoption families

We hear about low-income families and childcare providers being affected by the changes made by DESE, but there is a group of children that are being overlooked and deeply affected by this new system. These are the vulnerable and displaced protective service children that are wards of the State of Missouri. This means the State of Missouri is responsible for their safety, health, and needs. With the new system, foster and adoptive families are finding it hard to navigate and wait 60 to 90 days before applications are approved causing confusion and stress for the potential foster families. Childcare facilities are less likely to enroll a protective service child, due to the rule Providers can not charge foster families. If providers are not getting paid by DESE or by foster families, protective service children once again lose their battle for safety and security.

Foster and Adoptive families are waiting for 2 hours on hold, have long processing times, some up to 4 months, and must take off work to provide care for a child they are helping. When a middle-class family takes in a protective service child under the age of 5, they take on a big responsibility, the system is supposed to help foster families transition these children into these homes and into childcare with little to no stress on the foster families including financial stress.

Leah K – “it’s been a month my husband and I have rotated taking off work, we cannot afford to continue missing work, if we do not approve childcare by the end of the week, we will be forced to send him back”

Erin B – “I’m having trouble finding childcare because of the long approval waiting time, so I am no longer able to take in foster children at this time.”

Emily S – My adopted child was kicked out of daycare because of nonpayment for over two months from State after State promised to make the subsidy payments.”

In 2023 Missouri had 1,511 children under 5 in the protective service foster care system with Subsidy approvals taking months and providers not getting paid, foster families are starting to not except children under 5 and adoptive families are struggling to maintain financial burdens caused by this disruption.

The new system for childcare subsidy in the State of Missouri is broken and needs immediate solutions to help protect Foster and adoptive families, childcare, providers, and low-income families. We ask that payments for Subsidy be though authorization and not attendance and Protective service children be entered immediately in the Subsidy System.

With broken promises, with non-transparency, with mis information

We ask that you hear us when we say we need solutions now



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WITNESS NAME		
INDIVIDUAL:		
WITNESS NAME: SAMANTHA CROSS		PHONE NUMBER:
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:
ADDRESS: 3129 CHIPPEWA ST SAINT LOUIS MO		
CITY: SAINT LOUIS	STATE: MO	ZIP: 63118
ATTENDANCE: In-Person		SUBMIT DATE: 9/9/2024 3:37 PM
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WITNESS NAME			
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:			
WITNESS NAME: SAMANTHA CROSS		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: LITTLE PRECIOUS ANGELS CHILDCARE		TITLE: DIRECTOR	
ADDRESS: 3129 CHIPPEWA			
CITY: SAINT LOUIS		STATE: MO	ZIP: 63118
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:		SUBMIT DATE: 9/10/2024 12:00 AM
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COMMITTEE:
Elementary and Secondary Education

TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES

WITNESS NAME

INDIVIDUAL:

WITNESS NAME:
TRACY JAMES

PHONE NUMBER:

BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:

TITLE:

ADDRESS:
1223 BRITT LANE

CITY:
ROLLA

STATE:
MO

ZIP:
65401

EMAIL:

ATTENDANCE:

SUBMIT DATE:
9/10/2024 12:00 AM

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WITNESS NAME			
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:			
WITNESS NAME: WALLACE HARRIS		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: PETER RABBIT LEARNING AND DEVELOPMENT CENTER/LITTLE BUNNIES LLC		TITLE: ADMINISTRATOR	
ADDRESS: 3512 AND 3508 SOUTH 22ND STREET			
CITY: ST. JOSEPH		STATE: MO	ZIP: 64503
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:		SUBMIT DATE: 9/10/2024 12:00 AM
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